of that year and of their male counterparts? What should be the last ACR for finalizing the merit list? If we had done things on time, the last CR would have been the one just before the SB as per the extant policy. If that were to be followed, then what was the value of CRs earned after that cut-off year till the date of holding the SB? Were the dedicated women officers who had continued to work with their status uncertain and with nothing to gain not be compensated? Once again, I was of the opinion that we should just give PC to the 650-odd affected women officers and be done with it. However, others felt that we would then be doing an injustice to the corresponding male officers of those batches who had been screened out and neither granted PC nor had the Court ordered the largesse of grant of pensionary benefits. Hence, they felt that a screening was required, which was carried out and several women officers were not granted PC. These women officers promptly went to Court, which directed that instead of a batch-wise cut-off, anyone above a certain benchmark, even though lower than the cut-off, should be absorbed. This too was done, with the result that almost all of the affected women officers got PC. In hindsight, I should have stuck to my gut feeling.

With the grant of PC, these officers would now be eligible for promotion to the selection grade rank of Colonel. However, to be eligible for screening, all officers had to have undergone a certain mandatory course at prescribed service levels. While the women officers had undergone the Young Officers' Course of their respective services—Engineers, Signals, ASC, etc., as the case may be—they had not been detailed for the Junior Command (JC) and Senior Command (SC) Courses due to our myopic attitude. Nor had they been allowed to appear for the Defence Services Staff College (DSSC) Exam, which is an important career course. Permission for women officers

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